

Beams and dots

Beams and dots are two ways of making rhythms easier to read. Beams join groups of eighth or sixteenth notes. Dots, placed after the note head, extend the duration of the note by half again.

SEE ALSO

◀ 18–19 Notes on the staff

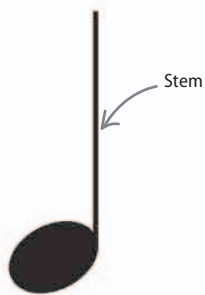
◀ 26–27 Note values

Time signatures

30–31 ▶

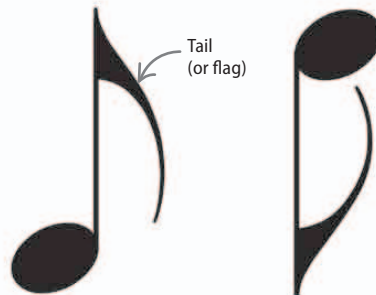
Stems and tails

The straight line attached to a quarter note head is called a stem. Upstems are written on the right-hand side of the note head, and downstems are written on the left of the note head. The curved line attached to an eighth note stem is called a tail or flag. Tails are always on the right-hand side of the stem, whether it's an upstem or a downstem.



△ Quarter note

A note with a stem but no tail is called a quarter note. Downstems are on the left, upstems are on the right.



△ Eighth note

A note with one tail is called an eighth. Two tails make it a sixteenth. The tail always goes on the right of the stem.

Beams

Two or more consecutive eighth notes can be joined together with a thick line called a beam, which replaces the individual tails. Sixteenth or thirty-second notes can also be joined in the same way. Beams are used to make the rhythm and beat structure as clear and easy to read as possible.



Eighth notes



Sixteenth notes



Thirty-second notes

REAL WORLD

Handwriting eighths

When writing eighths by hand, it is acceptable to use a straight line for the tail. The important thing when writing music by hand is to make it clear. The notehead should be either on the line or in a space. When writing a group of notes, ensure that there is good spacing between them.

